

abuse. I'm not sure if it affected my personal visibility, but I do hope it brought more attention to winter sports," she shares. "It was just your average trolls — but you know how they can go to extremes. It ranged from mild insults to death threats." But Tara remained undeterred.

"I chose this path knowing the challenges. I won't give up," she wrote on *Instagram*. Above all, she just wants to skate.

Tara's many hats

Yet, the Computer Science and Machine Learning student at the University of Colorado is much more than just a figure skater.

If someone were to visit Tara's own website and navigate to the 'Fun Facts' section, they would find four aspirations standing out: help develop figure skating in India; travel and explore the world; own a business; climb the Diamond Face of Long's Peak.

"I hope my performances are helping to grow figure skating in India," she says. "The rest are just things I want to do in life. Climbing will have to wait until I'm done skating, because that's a tough challenge — especially that particular route — and it takes serious training. And yes, I'd love to own a business and be financially secure." Tara's entrepreneurial spirit shows in unexpected ways: she loves making hot sauces and is currently experimenting with a recipe that blends Indian flavours.

Beyond her main *Instagram* account, she runs two more — one dedicated to her beloved 1997 Mazda M-edition Miata, and another chronicling her climbing exploits.

"Climbing is kind of a weekly hobby for me. It's a way to make friends outside skating," she says. She also enjoys hiking, which doubles as cardio training.

As for skating, Tara creates her own routines and designs and sews her own costumes. In figure skating, she explains, choreography and costumes must complement the music's theme — a task she embraces with ease.

In the past, Tara has performed to Indian compositions like *Padmaavat's* soundtrack and A.R. Rahman's *Adheeraa*, and hopes to incorporate more Tamil music to her routines.

Recently, she's chosen personal favourites — which explains the recurring presence of Lord Huron's *The Night We Met*.

TARA CREATES HER OWN SKATING ROUTINES AND DESIGNS AND SEWS HER OWN COSTUMES

Poise and grace: Tara Prasad performs during the 2022 ISU Four Continents Figure Skating Championships at the Tondiraba Ice Hall in Tallinn.
AFP